



mind-boggling. The recent win by the boys in the ICC Under-19 World Cup also promises that the talent tap will not run dry for a long time.

The Indian management and the think tank must be congratulated for their sagacity in showing faith in the squad, and despite the odd lack of form, their trust was repaid many times over by the players who were under scrutiny.

Sanju Samson is a prime example of how form can change in one innings. He was not even in the mix at the start of the tournament after a horrific time in the five-match T20I series against New Zealand, just before the World Cup started. Rinku Singh's father's condition worsening before his demise meant that Rinku left the team to go and see him. While he did return to the team, the management thought it better not to play him and opted to bring back Samson.

This meant there was a right and left-hand combination at the top of the batting order once again, and even as Abhishek Sharma faltered, Samson grabbed his chance and played three pearlers that would be remembered for years to come.

Purity of batting is generally a virtue in the longest format of the game, Test match cricket, and occasionally in the 50-over game, but hardly ever in the ultra-short format of the game. Samson provided that in all his three fifty-plus innings in playing classical cricket shots, along with some of the most imperious pulling and hooking seen in recent times. His pulling, off the fierce pace of Jofra Archer, was reminiscent of Viv Richards at his powerful best, though most of his batting is more like the Sri Lankan stylist Mahela Jayawardene.

Then, in the final, Abhishek Sharma came good with the quickest half-century in the T20 World Cup. Both the openers had, with their performances when it mattered most, justified the trust shown in them by the team's brains trust.

The win was a true team performance. While there will always be a star performer, at various times in the game, someone or the other put their hand up when required.

In Ishan Kishan making an emphatic comeback to the team, Hardik Pandya being the enforcer with both bat and ball, the

Jubilation: Suryakumar Yadav and Sunil Gavaskar celebrate after India won the ICC Men's T20 World Cup 2026 title. PTI

understated but destructive Shivam Dube hitting sixes for fun, and Tilak Varma and Axar Patel's all-round energies, the team found players doing above what was asked of them. Varun Chakaravathy and Arshdeep Singh, though expensive at times, kept on taking vital wickets.

No column, however, can end without the mention of Jasprit Bumrah. Samson and many other teammates call him a 'once-in-a-generation bowler', but he is more of a 'once-in-a-century bowler', without whom it would have been very tough for India. Every time the ball was given to him, he just bamboozled the batters with the many tricks up his sleeve. It was sheer delight to see him create magic and leave even a well-set batter looking clueless.

Well, done India. You not only repeated and defeated history, but also in doing so, created new history which will be forever cherished by those fortunate to have witnessed it.